
The Authorial Profile of Italian Writer and Philanthropist Grazia Pierantoni Mancini (1841–1915): Reconstructing Literary Networks through Archival Correspondence

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Abstract

The authorial profile of Italian writer and philanthropist Grazia Pierantoni Mancini (Naples, 1841–Rome, 1915) has long remained marginal within twentieth-century literary historiography despite her documented prominence in the cultural and intellectual life of post-Unification Italy. Scholarship has primarily focused on her autobiographical memoir *Impressioni e ricordi* (1908) and on her educational plays (Santoro 2001; Cagnolati 2012; Cagnolati 2021), while her broader literary, editorial, and transnational networks have received little sustained attention. The extensive archival collections preserved at the Museo Centrale del Risorgimento in Rome offer an opportunity to reassess both her authorial trajectory and the mechanisms through which literary visibility was constructed for women writers at the turn of the twentieth century.

This paper argues that Pierantoni Mancini occupied a far more central position within Italian and European literary culture than her subsequent historiographical marginalization would suggest. The analysis is based on a survey of several hundred letters, telegrams, and related documents preserved in the Grazia Pierantoni Mancini, Pasquale Stanislao Mancini, and Augusto Pierantoni archival fonds. These documents include correspondence with publishers, editors, translators, journalists, political figures, and fellow writers, alongside manuscripts, publication records, and documentary traces of theatrical performances and literary reception. Methodologically, the study combines close philological reading with historical network analysis. Correspondents are treated as nodes and epistolary exchanges as relational ties, allowing the reconstruction of patterns of collaboration, mediation, patronage, translation, and circulation. Rather than treating correspondence merely as biographical evidence, the paper examines letters as records of cultural transactions that reveal how literary careers were negotiated.

The correspondence reveals a dense and geographically extensive network linking Pierantoni Mancini to major figures of the Italian literary field, including Giosuè Carducci, Matilde Serao, Luigi Capuana, Antonio Gallenga, Antonio Giulio Barrili, and Grazia Deledda. It also documents sustained relationships with translators, editors, and intellectuals in France, Germany, Britain, Sweden, Romania, Hungary, Portugal, and the Netherlands. These exchanges provide evidence of translation projects, negotiations with periodicals, publishing strategies, theatrical performances, and efforts to secure international circulation for her works. The archive thus represents the only possibility to fully reconstruct the author's contemporary

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reception, given that her profile has fallen into oblivion in subsequent literary history.

By foregrounding correspondence as a source for network reconstruction, this paper contributes to current debates on literary sociology and women's authorship. It demonstrates that network analysis can illuminate forms of agency and influence that remain invisible in traditional author-centred narratives and highlights how archival evidence can challenge established literary canons. More broadly, the case of Pierantoni Mancini illustrates the importance of combining qualitative and relational approaches to recover the historical significance of women whose cultural authority was substantial in their own time but diminished in later historiography.

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